



A WORKER on the roof of a new home in Irvine in September. An estimated 41% of construction workers in California are immigrants.

## Pasadena Unified schools in tumult

With five campuses destroyed by fire and others closed, the district is scrambling.

BY TERESA WATANABE AND DANIEL MILLER

Kira Weibel was in eighth grade when the COVID-19 pandemic shut down the student's Altadena charter school, cutting off critical community connections. As the weeks and months of on-line learning and isolation dragged on, Weibel spiraled into a deep depression.

That changed when the school, Aveson Global Leadership Academy, reopened a year later and brought back the social interaction. But now Weibel and thousands of other students who weathered the pandemic are struggling with another historic calamity: the Eaton and Palisades fires. The ferocious flames that tore through the foothill community of Altadena and the coastal enclave of Pacific Palisades have upended their lives, with homes lost, schooling disrupted, extracurricular activities canceled and close-knit communities scattered.

"The pandemic took a really hard toll on my mental health, and getting back into

## LAFD prepared for winds in 2011 — but not this time

Aggressive measures weren't employed before Palisades fire

BY ALENE TCHKEDYAN AND PAUL PRINGLE

Thirteen years ago, Los Angeles Fire Department officials were bracing for the kind of dangerous winds that could drive flames across hill-sides and canyons and tear through neighborhoods from Malibu to Pacific Palisades to the San Fernando Valley.

The National Weather Service

had issued red flag warnings of doomsday gusts as fierce as 90 mph. Forecasters described the coming windstorm as a once-every-five-to-10-years calamity.

So the LAFD began to marshal its defenses in the days before the arrival of the winds, taking the type of dramatic measures that the department failed to employ this month in advance of the Palisades fire, which followed wind alerts as bad or worse, due to the lack of recent rain, than

those of late November 2011.

With the tempest expected to hit on Dec. 1 that year, LAFD commanders ordered up at least 40 extra fire engines for stations closest to the areas where the fire hazards were greatest, including the Palisades, The Times has learned through interviews and internal department records.

Among the additional rigs were more than 20 that were pre-deployed

## A nightmare for the vulnerable

STEVE LOPEZ

Fires ambushed the back of the building, and savage winds battered the windows while staffers at the Two Palms Nursing Center in Altadena raced to evacuate roughly four dozen elderly and disabled residents.

It was Jan. 7, that first night of the deadly Eaton fire, and Brenda Robinson, 76, a retired bookkeeper who is immobilized by a chronic tissue disease, "prayed to Jehovah" as an aide helped her into a wheelchair.

In another room, Valerie Fine, 66, a retired teacher who has multiple sclerosis and is unable to walk, smelled smoke.

"They rushed in and put N95s on us," Fine said. "Thank God they did



VALERIE FINE, left, chats with fellow Eaton fire evacuee Brenda Robinson in their room at the Golden Legacy Care Center in Sylmar.

## First steps of Israel and Hamas cease-fire begin

Some Israeli hostages are freed, but Palestinian prisoners aren't yet

BY NABIH BULOS AND BILAL SHBAIR

DEIR AL BALAH, Gaza Strip — A cease-fire between Hamas and Israel took effect Sunday, silencing the guns over Gaza and renewing hopes of a possible end to a 15-month conflict that has killed tens of thousands and edged the Middle East to all-out regional war.

By late afternoon, an exchange of Israeli hostages and Palestinian prisoners and detainees had begun.

Three hostages were handed over to Israeli forces — the first of 33 expected to be freed over the next six weeks in exchange for about 1,900 Palestinians. Israeli authorities were assembling

the first 90 at Ofer prison in the West Bank, but by early Monday morning they still had not been freed.

The deal follows months of tortuous negotiations led by Qatar, Egypt and the United States, with the Qataris regularly expressing frustration and threatening to walk away at one point.

The precariousness of the deal was highlighted even before the fighting stopped.

The cease-fire had been set for 8:30 a.m., with plans for three female hostages to be exchanged for dozens of Palestinian prisoners later in the day.

But in the hours ahead of the deadline, Hamas failed to send the list of hostage



MEMBERS of the Qassam Brigades, Hamas' armed wing, celebrate the latest cease-fire between Hamas and Israel in Deir al Balah, Gaza Strip, on Sunday.

## Trump migrant policies may slow rebuild

Mass deportations would hinder L.A. fire recovery as home builders rely heavily on immigrant labor.

BY RACHEL URANGA, RUBEN VIVES AND LIAM DILLON

The breeze was tinged with smoke from the fires that burned through Pacific Palisades as dozens of workers finished up the brick facade of a sprawling home in the tony Brentwood Park neighborhood.

The talk was in Spanish, an unremarkable fact given the language has been the lingua franca on most construction sites in Southern California for decades.

But that fact could be at the center of a leviathan clash of interests: the need to rebuild thousands of homes that were incinerated on a scale the city had never seen before, and the promises of an incoming president to deport a good percentage of the workers who would be needed to get that colossal undertaking done.

"Everyone is scared," said Melvin Merino, 36, a painter at the home. Workers "are reluctant to talk about their immigration status out of fear it may be shared with immigration officials."

Even in a city that is supportive of the immigrant population, his fears could make him and others cautious to take jobs in high-profile areas such as the fire zone.

President-elect Donald Trump has vowed to execute the largest mass deportation program of unauthorized immigrants in U.S. history and "seal" the borders from immigrants. Trump's border czar, Tom Homan, promises to bring back worksite enforcement.

Immigrant rights groups are bracing for widespread roundups and expulsions, holding legal workshops up and down the state in a bid to aid residents who might be stopped by federal authorities.

The threat is rattling the construction industry, which already has a labor shortage. The wildfires that

### Wind forecast for week gets worse

Agency again issues its most urgent fire risk warning. CALIFORNIA, B1

### Tariffs could hurt rebuilding effort

Plan for tax on Canadian imports could raise price of lumber. BUSINESS, A10

### World prepares for Trump 2.0

There's a sense that those outside the U.S. have a better idea of what to expect this time. NATION, A5

### Rams' season comes to an end

On a snowy, windy day, Saquon Barkley leads Philadelphia past L.A. in a divisional-round game. SPORTS, D1

### Weather

Sunshine and warmer. L.A. Basin: 70/44. B6

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